

Animal Detectives:

Classification Mission

Grade 3 Science • Animal Unit • Lesson 3



Ms. Smith • April 2026



Today's Learning Goals

1

Learn how to classify animals



2

Tell mammals from non-mammals



3

Think like a detective!



What is Classification?

Classification is
grouping things
based on their
similarities.



Our Detective Tools

Good detectives use...



Observation



Questions



Clues



Evidence



Let's use our tools!





Case 1: Is This a Fish?



Some people
think **whales**
are **fish**.
Are they right?

Let's investigate!



Clue 1: Where Does It Live?

Whales live in **water**.

Many **fish** live in **water**,
too.

Clue noted! ✓





Clue 2: How Does It Breathe?

Whales come to the surface to breathe **air** through a **blowhole**.

Fish breathe **underwater** with **gills**.



♥ Clue 3: What Are Its Babies Like? ♥

Whale moms give birth to **live babies** and **nurse** them with milk.

Fish lay **eggs**.



Detective Conclusion! 💡

Whales have lungs,
give birth to **live babies**,
and nurse with **milk**.

Whales are
MAMMALS, not fish!



Case 2: Is This a Bird?

Some people
think **bats**
are birds.
Are they right?

Let's investigate! ✓





Clue 1: What Does It Have?



Bats have **fur**.

Birds have **feathers**.



 Bat



 Bird



Are these clues the **same** or **different**?





Clue 2: How Does It Move?



Bats have **wings**,
but they are made
of **skin** stretched
between fingers.

Birds have **feathers**
on their wings.

 Bat



Wings are
made of **skin**
stretched
between fingers.

 Bird



Wings have
feathers
on them.

?



Are these clues the **same** or **different**?

Think!

What helps you
move—skin or
feathers?





Clue 3: How Are Babies Cared For?



Baby bats are
born live and
nursed with **milk**.

Bats have **fur**.



 **Bat**

Baby birds hatch
from **eggs** and
are fed **worms**
by their parents.

Birds have
feathers.



 **Bird**

?



Are these clues the **same** or **different**?

**Think Like
a Detective!** 

What helps
us take care of
our babies?



Detective Conclusion! 💡

Bats have **fur**,
give birth to **live babies**,
and nurse with **milk**.

Bats are **MAMMALS**,
not birds!



REMEMBER!

Bat
= Mammal



Not Bird!

Bird
= Bird



Not Mammal!

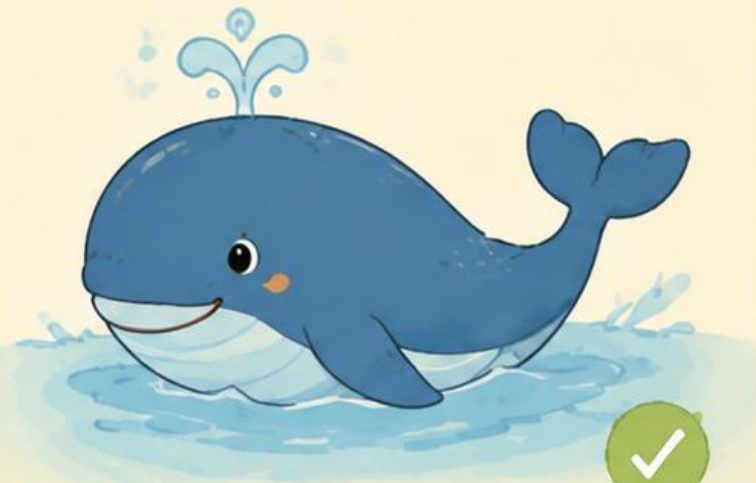
Think Like a Detective! 🔍

- ✓ Look for clues.
- ✓ Ask questions.
- ✓ Find evidence.
- ✓ Make a conclusion.

Great detectives
solve **BIG** mysteries! 🐾

REMEMBER!

Whale
= Mammal



Not Fish!

Bat
= Mammal



Not Bird!



Think Like
a Detective! 🔍

- ✓ Look for clues.
- ✓ Ask questions.
- ✓ Find evidence.
- ✓ Make a conclusion.

Great detectives
solve **BIG** mysteries!



✨ Think Like a Detective! 🔍



Look for clues.



Ask questions.



Find evidence.



Make a conclusion.

✨ Great detectives
solve **BIG** mysteries! ✨



Keep exploring and asking questions! ❤️

Let's Investigate!

Look at the pictures. Decide if each animal is a mammal or not.

1



2



3



4



5



6



Remember!

Mammals have hair
or fur and drink milk
from their mothers.



Mammals



Not Mammals

✧ Deep Think Question? ✧



Why is it important
to **classify**
animals correctly?



✧ Mission Summary ✧

Let's remember what we learned about animals!



What is a Mammal?

Mammals have **hair or fur**
and drink **milk**
from their mothers.



What is NOT a Mammal?

Animals **without hair or fur**
and **do not** drink milk
from their mothers.



What We Learned

- ✓ Mammals have hair or fur.
- ✓ Mammals drink milk from their mothers.
- ✓ We can sort animals into mammals and not mammals.

★ You are a great animal detective! ★



Great Job,
Detective!

Well Done!

You are an amazing animal detective!

Today we learned how to classify animals.

 We can:

- ✓ Identify mammals.
- ✓ Identify animals that are **not mammals**.
- ✓ Sort animals into the correct groups.

 We explored:

Mammals



Not Mammals



★ Great job today!

See you on our next adventure!

